Learn French for Beginners

French Grammar Tables

Quick reference for English speakers, A1–B1

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One place for the small words and patterns you need every day: articles, pronouns, possessives, this and that, question words, negatives, adjectives, prepositions, a verb summary, and numbers, dates and the time. Each table says when to use it, gives every French item with its pronunciation and a Listen button, then examples and the mistakes to watch out for.

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Pronunciation key

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

Pronunciations use the same English-style respelling as the verb guides (no IPA). Tables marked Preview go a little beyond A2. Final consonants are usually silent (*parlent* = "parl"). A hyphen joins syllables said as one word; a liaison consonant is written at the start of the next syllable (*les amis* = lay zah-mee).

1. Articles

Almost every French noun comes with a small word in front of it. These tables show which one to use.

Definite articles: the

When: For a specific thing ("the book"), and for things in general after verbs of liking: J'aime le café = I like coffee.

Definite articles: le, la, l', les

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
le	*luh*	the	m. sing.
la	*lah*	the	f. sing.
l'	*l*	the	sing., before a vowel or mute h
les	*lay*	the	pl. (m. and f.)

- **Le train arrive.** *(luh traN ah-reev)* — *The train is arriving.*
- **La gare est loin.** *(lah gar eh lwaN)* — *The station is far.*
- **L'hôtel est petit.** *(loh-tel eh puh-tee)* — *The hotel is small.*
- **J'aime les chats.** *(zhem lay shah)* — *I like cats.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~J'aime café.~~ → ✓ **J'aime le café.** *(zhem luh kah-fay)* — French keeps the article for things in general.
> - ✗ ~~le ami~~ → ✓ **l'ami** *(lah-mee)* — le and la become l' before a vowel or a mute h.
> - les before a vowel makes a liaison z: les amis (lay zah-mee).

Indefinite articles: a, an, some

When: For one thing that isn't specific ("a book"), and des for "some" with things you can count.

Indefinite articles: un, une, des

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
un	*uhN*	a, an	m. sing.
une	*ewn*	a, an	f. sing.
des	*day*	some	pl. (m. and f.)

- **J'ai un frère.** *(zhay uhN frair)* — *I have a brother.*
- **Elle a une voiture.** *(el ah ewn vwah-tewr)* — *She has a car.*
- **Il y a des pommes.** *(eel ee ah day pum)* — *There are (some) apples.*
- **Je suis professeur.** *(zhuh swee proh-feh-suhr)* — *I am a teacher. (no article for a job after être)*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Je suis un professeur.~~ → ✓ **Je suis professeur.** *(zhuh swee proh-feh-suhr)* — no un/une before a job after être.
> - ✗ ~~J'ai pommes.~~ → ✓ **J'ai des pommes.** *(zhay day pum)* — English can drop "some"; French can't drop des.

Partitive articles: some

When: For an amount of something you can't count: some bread, some water. Very common with food and drink, after

manger, boire, prendre and vouloir.

Partitive articles: du, de la, de l', des

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
du	*dew*	some	m.
de la	*duh lah*	some	f.
de l'	*duh l*	some	before a vowel or mute h
des	*day*	some	pl.

- **Je voudrais du pain.** *(zhuh voo-dreh dew paN)* — *I'd like some bread.*
- **Tu bois de la bière ?** *(tew bwah duh lah byair)* — *Do you drink beer?*
- **Il prend de l'eau.** *(eel prahN duh loh)* — *He's having some water.*
- **Nous mangeons des légumes.** *(noo mahN-zhohN day lay-gewm)* — *We eat vegetables.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Je mange pain.~~ → ✓ **Je mange du pain.** *(zhuh mahNzh dew paN)* — an amount of something always takes du / de la / de l'.
> - ✗ ~~J'aime du café.~~ → ✓ **J'aime le café.** *(zhem luh kah-fay)* — after aimer, adorer, détester and préférer use le/la/les (things in general).

See also: manger · boire · prendre.

À and de + the article: au, aux, du, des

When: à (to, at) and de (of, from) melt together with le and les. They do not change with la or l'.

à and de with le, la, l', les

French	Pronunciation	English	Made from
au	*oh*	to the, at the	à + le
à la	*ah lah*	to the, at the	à + la (no change)
à l'	*ah l*	to the, at the	à + l' (no change)
aux	*oh*	to the, at the	à + les
du	*dew*	of the, from the	de + le
de la	*duh lah*	of the, from the	de + la (no change)
de l'	*duh l*	of the, from the	de + l' (no change)
des	*day*	of the, from the	de + les

- **Je vais au cinéma.** *(zhuh veh oh see-nay-mah)* — *I'm going to the cinema.*
- **Elle est à la gare.** *(el eh tah lah gar)* — *She is at the station.*
- **Il parle aux enfants.** *(eel parl oh zahN-fahN)* — *He is talking to the children.*
- **Je reviens du marché.** *(zhuh ruh-vyaN dew mar-shay)* — *I'm coming back from the market.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Je vais à le parc.~~ → ✓ **Je vais au parc.** *(zhuh veh oh park)* — à + le is always au.
> - ✗ ~~la porte de le garage~~ → ✓ **la porte du garage** *(lah port dew gah-rahzh)* — de + le is always du.

Pas de: after a negative

When: After a negative, un, une, du, de la, de l' and des all become de (d' before a vowel). Exception: after être, keep

the article.

de after a negative: pas de, pas d', plus de, jamais de

French	Pronunciation	English	Use
pas de	*pah duh*	no, not any	before a consonant
pas d'	*pah d*	no, not any	before a vowel or mute h
plus de	*plew duh*	no more	ne ... plus
jamais de	*zhah-meh duh*	never any	ne ... jamais

- **Je n'ai pas de voiture.** *(zhuh nay pah duh vwah-tewr)* — *I don't have a car.*
- **Il ne boit pas d'alcool.** *(eel nuh bwah pah dahl-kohl)* — *He doesn't drink alcohol.*
- **Nous n'avons plus de pain.** *(noo nah-vohN plew duh paN)* — *We have no more bread.*
- **Ce n'est pas un problème.** *(suh neh pah zuhN proh-blem)* — *It isn't a problem. (after être, keep un)*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je n'ai pas une voiture.~~ → ✓ **Je n'ai pas de voiture.** *(zhuh nay pah duh vwah-tewr)* — un/une/des become de after pas.
> - ✗ ~~Je n'aime pas de café.~~ → ✓ **Je n'aime pas le café.** *(zhuh nem pah luh kah-fay)* — le/la/les don't change.

See also: Negative words.

Which article?

When: A quick decision guide: what you mean decides the article.

Choosing between le, un, du and de

French	Pronunciation	English	Example
le, la, les	*luh, lah, lay*	the, things in general	J'aime le thé.
un, une	*uhN, ewn*	one countable thing	Je veux une pomme.
des	*day*	several countable things	Je veux des pommes.
du, de la	*dew, duh lah*	an amount you can't count	Je veux du thé.
de	*duh*	after a negative	Je ne veux pas de thé.

- **Je prends un café et de l'eau.** *(zhuh prahN uhN kah-fay ay duh loh)* — *I'll have a coffee and some water.*
- **Le café est chaud.** *(luh kah-fay eh shoh)* — *The coffee is hot.*

> **Watch out**
> - In English you can often say nothing ("I eat bread"); in French a noun almost always needs an article.

2. Pronouns

Subject pronouns

When: Who does the action. They come before the verb.

Subject pronouns: je, tu, il, elle, on, nous, vous, ils, elles

French	Pronunciation	English	Use
je	*zhuh*	I	j' before a vowel
tu	*tew*	you	one person, informal
il	*eel*	he, it	m.
elle	*el*	she, it	f.
on	*ohN*	we, one, people	il/elle verb form
nous	*noo*	we	
vous	*voo*	you	formal, or more than one person
ils	*eel*	they	m. or mixed group
elles	*el*	they	f. only

- **On va au cinéma ?** *(ohN vah oh see-nay-mah)* — *Shall we go to the cinema?*
- **Vous êtes prêts ?** *(voo zet preh)* — *Are you (all) ready?*
- **Ils arrivent demain.** *(eel zah-reev duh-maN)* — *They arrive tomorrow.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~On allons au parc.~~ → ✓ **On va au parc.** *(ohN vah oh park)* — on means "we" but takes the il/elle form.
> - A group of nine women and one man is ils, not elles.

Stressed pronouns: moi, toi...

When: On their own (Moi !), after a preposition (avec moi, chez toi), after c'est, and for emphasis (Moi, je reste.).

Stressed pronouns: moi, toi, lui, elle, nous, vous, eux, elles

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
moi	*mwah*	me	
toi	*twah*	you	
lui	*lwee*	him	m.
elle	*el*	her	f.
nous	*noo*	us	
vous	*voo*	you	
eux	*uh*	them	m. or mixed
elles	*el*	them	f.

- **Tu viens avec moi ?** *(tew vyaN ah-vek mwah)* — *Are you coming with me?*
- **C'est pour lui.** *(seh poor lwee)* — *It's for him.*
- **Moi, je préfère le thé.** *(mwah, zhuh pray-fair luh tay)* — *Me, I prefer tea.*
- **On mange chez eux.** *(ohN mahNzh shay zuh)* — *We're eating at their place.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~avec je~~ → ✓ **avec moi** *(ah-vek mwah)* — after a preposition use the stressed form.
> - ✗ ~~Je aussi.~~ → ✓ **Moi aussi.** *(mwah oh-see)* — on its own, use moi.

Direct object pronouns: me, le, la...

When: They replace the thing or person that receives the action directly (no à): Je vois Marie → Je la vois. They go before the verb.

Direct object pronouns: me, te, le, la, nous, vous, les

French	Pronunciation	English	Use
me	*muh*	me	m' before a vowel
te	*tuh*	you	t' before a vowel
le	*luh*	him, it	m.; l' before a vowel
la	*lah*	her, it	f.; l' before a vowel
nous	*noo*	us	
vous	*voo*	you	
les	*lay*	them	pl.

- **Je le vois.** *(zhuh luh vwah)* — *I see him / it.*
- **Tu la connais ?** *(tew lah koh-neh)* — *Do you know her?*
- **Il m'aime.** *(eel mem)* — *He loves me.*
- **Je les achète.** *(zhuh lay zah-shet)* — *I'm buying them.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je vois le.~~ → ✓ **Je le vois.** *(zhuh luh vwah)* — the pronoun goes before the verb.
> - ✗ ~~Je regarde lui.~~ → ✓ **Je le regarde.** *(zhuh luh ruh-gard)* — regarder takes a direct object: le, not lui.

See also: Order of object pronouns.

Indirect object pronouns: me, lui, leur...

When: They replace à + a person: Je parle à Paul → Je lui parle. Common with parler à, donner à, dire à, téléphoner à, écrire à and demander à.

Indirect object pronouns: me, te, lui, nous, vous, leur

French	Pronunciation	English	Use
me	*muh*	to me	m' before a vowel
te	*tuh*	to you	t' before a vowel
lui	*lwee*	to him, to her	m. and f.
nous	*noo*	to us	
vous	*voo*	to you	
leur	*luhr*	to them	m. and f.; never leurs

- **Je lui parle.** *(zhuh lwee parl)* — *I'm talking to him / to her.*
- **Tu leur téléphones ?** *(tew luhr tay-lay-fohn)* — *Are you phoning them?*
- **Elle m'écrit.** *(el may-kree)* — *She writes to me.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je leurs donne.~~ → ✓ **Je leur donne.** *(zhuh luhr dun)* — the pronoun leur never takes an s.
> - ✗ ~~Je la téléphone.~~ → ✓ **Je lui téléphone.** *(zhuh lwee tay-lay-fohn)* — téléphoner à: indirect.

See also: parler · donner · dire.

Reflexive pronouns

When: With pronominal verbs (se lever, s'appeler) the action comes back to the subject. The full lessons are in the

Reflexive verbs topic.

Reflexive pronouns: me, te, se, nous, vous, se

French	Pronunciation	English	With
me	*muh*	myself	je; m' before a vowel
te	*tuh*	yourself	tu; t' before a vowel
se	*suh*	himself, herself, itself	il, elle, on; s' before a vowel
nous	*noo*	ourselves	nous
vous	*voo*	yourself, yourselves	vous
se	*suh*	themselves	ils, elles; s' before a vowel

- **Je me lève à sept heures.** *(zhuh muh lev ah set uhr)* — *I get up at seven.*
- **Comment tu t'appelles ?** *(koh-mahN tew tah-pel)* — *What's your name?*
- **Nous nous habillons.** *(noo noo zah-bee-yohN)* — *We're getting dressed.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Je lève à sept heures.~~ → ✓ **Je me lève à sept heures.** *(zhuh muh lev ah set uhr)* — keep the pronoun even when English has no "myself".

See also: Reflexive verbs, lesson 1 · se lever · s'appeler.

Y and en

When: y replaces à + a place or thing (there, about it); en replaces de + a thing, and any quantity (some, of it, of them).

The pronouns y and en

French	Pronunciation	English	Use
y	*ee*	there, about it	replaces à + place / thing
en	*ahN*	some, any, of it, of them, from there	replaces de + thing, or a quantity
il y a	*eel ee ah*	there is, there are	fixed phrase
j'en ai deux	*zhahN nay duh*	I have two (of them)	en + number

- **Tu vas à Paris ? Oui, j'y vais.** *(tew vah zah pah-ree / wee, zhee veh)* — *Are you going to Paris? Yes, I'm going (there).*
- **Je pense à mon travail. J'y pense.** *(zhuh pahNs ah mohN trah-vahy / zhee pahNs)* — *I'm thinking about my work. I'm thinking about it.*
- **Tu veux du café ? Oui, j'en veux.** *(tew vuh dew kah-fay / wee, zhahN vuh)* — *Do you want some coffee? Yes, I want some.*
- **Combien de frères as-tu ? J'en ai deux.** *(kohN-byaN duh frair ah-tew / zhahN nay duh)* — *How many brothers do you have? I have two.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Oui, je vais.~~ → ✓ **Oui, j'y vais.** *(wee, zhee veh)* — aller needs a place: use y.
> - ✗ ~~J'ai deux.~~ → ✓ **J'en ai deux.** *(zhahN nay duh)* — with a number and no noun, add en.
> - For people, use lui/leur or à + a stressed pronoun, not y: Je pense à elle (zhuh pahNs ah el).

Order of object pronouns Preview

When: When two object pronouns go before the verb, they follow this order (B1).

Order of object pronouns before the verb

French	Pronunciation	English	Position
me, te, se, nous, vous	*muh, tuh, suh, noo, voo*	me, you, oneself, us, you	1st
le, la, les	*luh, lah, lay*	him, her, it, them	2nd
lui, leur	*lwee, luhr*	to him / her, to them	3rd
y	*ee*	there	4th
en	*ahN*	some, of it	5th

- **Il me le donne.** *(eel muh luh dun) — He gives it to me.*
- **Je le lui donne.** *(zhuh luh lwee dun) — I give it to him / her.*
- **Je vous en prie.** *(zhuh voo zahN pree) — You're welcome. (set phrase)*
- **Il y en a trois.** *(eel ee ahN nah trwah) — There are three (of them).*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je lui le donne.~~ → ✓ **Je le lui donne.** *(zhuh luh lwee dun)* — le/la/les come before lui/leur.
> - In a compound tense the pronouns go before avoir/être: Je le lui ai donné (zhuh luh lwee ay doh-nay).

Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont

When: They join two sentences about the same noun ("the man who...", "the film that...").

Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont

French	Pronunciation	English	Replaces
qui	*kee*	who, which, that	the subject (a verb follows)
que	*kuh*	whom, which, that	the object (a subject follows); qu' before a vowel
où	*oo*	where, when	a place or a time
dont	*dohN*	whose, of which, about which	de + noun (B1)

- **L'homme qui parle est mon père.** *(lum kee parl eh mohN pair) — The man who is talking is my father.*
- **Le film que je regarde est long.** *(luh feelm kuh zhuh ruh-gard eh lohN) — The film (that) I'm watching is long.*
- **La ville où j'habite est petite.** *(lah veel oo zhah-beet eh puh-teet) — The town where I live is small.*
- **Le livre dont je parle est ici.** *(luh leevr dohN zhuh parl eh tee-see) — The book I'm talking about is here.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~le film qui je regarde~~ → ✓ **le film que je regarde** *(luh feelm kuh zhuh ruh-gard)* — a subject (je) follows, so que.
> - English often drops "that"; French never drops que.

3. Possessives

Possessive adjectives: my, your, his...

When: Before a noun. They agree with the THING owned, not the owner: sa voiture = his car or her car.

Possessive adjectives: mon, ma, mes, ton, ta, tes, son, sa, ses, notre, nos, votre, vos, leur, leurs

French	Pronunciation	English	With
mon	*mohN*	my	m. sing.; f. before a vowel
ma	*mah*	my	f. sing.
mes	*may*	my	pl.
ton	*tohN*	your	m. sing.; f. before a vowel
ta	*tah*	your	f. sing.
tes	*tay*	your	pl.
son	*sohN*	his, her, its	m. sing.; f. before a vowel
sa	*sah*	his, her, its	f. sing.
ses	*say*	his, her, its	pl.
notre	*noh-truh*	our	sing.
nos	*noh*	our	pl.
votre	*voh-truh*	your	sing.
vos	*voh*	your	pl.
leur	*luhr*	their	sing.
leurs	*luhr*	their	pl.

- **C'est mon amie Claire.** *(seh mohN nah-mee klair) — This is my friend Claire. (amie is f., but mon before a vowel)*
- **Paul aime sa mère.** *(pohl em sah mair) — Paul loves his mother.*
- **Marie aime son père.** *(mah-ree em sohN pair) — Marie loves her father.*
- **Ils vendent leur maison.** *(eel vahNd luhr meh-zohN) — They're selling their house.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~ma amie~~ → ✓ **mon amie** *(mohN nah-mee)* — ma, ta, sa become mon, ton, son before a vowel.
> - ✗ ~~Marie aime sa père.~~ → ✓ **Marie aime son père.** *(mah-ree em sohN pair)* — agree with père (m.), not with Marie.

Possessive pronouns: mine, yours...

When: They replace possessive + noun: mon livre → le mien (mine). They agree with the thing owned.

Possessive pronouns: le mien, le tien, le sien, le nôtre, le vôtre, le leur

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
le mien	*luh myaN*	mine	m. sing.
la mienne	*lah myen*	mine	f. sing.
les miens	*lay myaN*	mine	m. pl.
les miennes	*lay myen*	mine	f. pl.
le tien	*luh tyaN*	yours	m. sing.
la tienne	*lah tyen*	yours	f. sing.
les tiens	*lay tyaN*	yours	m. pl.
les tiennes	*lay tyen*	yours	f. pl.
le sien	*luh syaN*	his, hers	m. sing.
la sienne	*lah syen*	his, hers	f. sing.
les siens	*lay syaN*	his, hers	m. pl.
les siennes	*lay syen*	his, hers	f. pl.
le nôtre	*luh noh-truh*	ours	m. sing.
la nôtre	*lah noh-truh*	ours	f. sing.
les nôtres	*lay noh-truh*	ours	pl.
le vôtre	*luh voh-truh*	yours	m. sing.
la vôtre	*lah voh-truh*	yours	f. sing.
les vôtres	*lay voh-truh*	yours	pl.
le leur	*luh luhr*	theirs	m. sing.
la leur	*lah luhr*	theirs	f. sing.
les leurs	*lay luhr*	theirs	pl.

- **Ce n'est pas ton stylo, c'est le mien.** *(suh neh pah tohN stee-loh, seh luh myaN) — It's not your pen, it's mine.*
- **Ta voiture est rouge, la mienne est bleue.** *(tah vwah-tewr eh roozh, lah myen eh bluh) — Your car is red; mine is blue.*
- **Nos enfants jouent avec les leurs.** *(noh zahN-fahN zhoo ah-vek lay luhr) — Our children play with theirs.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~C'est mien.~~ → ✓ **C'est le mien.** *(seh luh myaN)* — keep the article. Casual alternative: C'est à moi (seh tah mwah).
> - notre and votre (no accent) vs le nôtre and le vôtre (with an accent, a longer o). Both are respelled noh / voh.

4. Demonstratives

Demonstrative adjectives: this, that, these

When: Before a noun to point at it: this / that / these / those. Add -ci (here) or -là (there) to contrast.

Demonstrative adjectives: ce, cet, cette, ces

French	Pronunciation	English	With
ce	*suh*	this, that	m. sing.
cet	*set*	this, that	m. sing. before a vowel or mute h
cette	*set*	this, that	f. sing.
ces	*say*	these, those	pl.
ce livre-ci	*suh leevr-see*	this book (here)	-ci = here
ce livre-là	*suh leevr-lah*	that book (there)	-là = there

- **Ce café est délicieux.** *(suh kah-fay eh day-lee-syuh)* — *This coffee is delicious.*
- **Cet hôtel est cher.** *(set oh-tel eh shair)* — *This hotel is expensive.*
- **Cette semaine, je travaille.** *(set suh-men, zhuh trah-vahy)* — *This week I'm working.*
- **Tu préfères cette robe-ci ou cette robe-là ?** *(tew pray-fair set rob-see oo set rob-lah)* — *Do you prefer this dress or that one?*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~ce homme~~ → ✓ **cet homme** *(set um)* — before a vowel or mute h, the masculine is cet.
> - ✗ ~~cet femme~~ → ✓ **cette femme** *(set fahm)* — cet and cette sound the same, but cet is only masculine.
> - Liaison: ces amis (say zah-mee).

Demonstrative pronouns: this one, that one Preview

When: They replace ce/cette/ces + noun. Never alone: always followed by -ci / -là, qui / que, or de (B1).

Demonstrative pronouns: celui, celle, ceux, celles

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
celui	*suh-lwee*	the one, this one	m. sing.
celle	*sel*	the one, this one	f. sing.
ceux	*suh*	the ones, these	m. pl.
celles	*sel*	the ones, these	f. pl.
celui-ci	*suh-lwee-see*	this one (here)	m. sing.
celle-là	*sel-lah*	that one (there)	f. sing.

- **Je prends celui-ci.** *(zhuh prahN suh-lwee-see)* — *I'll take this one. (un pull)*
- **C'est celle de ma sœur.** *(seh sel duh mah suhr)* — *It's my sister's. (la voiture)*
- **Ceux qui veulent venir sont les bienvenus.** *(suh kee vuhl vuh-neer sohN lay byaN-vuh-new)* — *Those who want to come are welcome.*
- **Quelle robe ? Celle que tu portes.** *(kel rob / sel kuh tew port)* — *Which dress? The one you're wearing.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Je prends celui.~~ → ✓ **Je prends celui-ci.** *(zhuh prahN suh-lwee-see)* — celui needs -ci, -là, qui, que or de after it.
> - "Paul's" is celui de Paul (suh-lwee duh pohl): French has no 's.

C'est or il est?

When: c'est + a noun with its article or a name (C'est un ami, C'est Marie). il est / elle est + an adjective or a job on its own (Il est grand, Elle est médecin).

c'est, ce sont, il est, elle est

French	Pronunciation	English	Followed by
c'est	*seh*	it is, this is, he is, she is	article + noun, a name, a stressed pronoun
ce sont	*suh sohN*	they are, these are	plural noun
il est	*eel eh*	he is, it is	adjective or job, no article
elle est	*el eh*	she is, it is	adjective or job, no article

- **C'est un bon restaurant.** *(seh tuhN bohN res-toh-rahN)* — *It's a good restaurant.*
- **Il est médecin.** *(eel eh mayd-saN)* — *He's a doctor.*
- **C'est un médecin célèbre.** *(seh tuhN mayd-saN say-lebr)* — *He's a famous doctor.*
- **C'est beau !** *(seh boh)* — *That's beautiful! (about an idea or a view in general)*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Il est un ami.~~ → ✓ **C'est un ami.** *(seh tuhN nah-mee)* — un/une + noun after "he is" → c'est.
> - ✗ ~~C'est médecin.~~ → ✓ **Il est médecin.** *(eel eh mayd-saN)* — a job with no article → il est / elle est.

5. Questions

A quick reference. For the full lessons with exercises, see the Asking questions topic.

See also: Asking questions (topic) · Where, when, how, why (lesson 3) · Who and what (lesson 4) · Which: quel (lesson 5).

Question words

When: To ask for information. Put est-ce que after the word for the standard style: Où est-ce que tu vas ?

Question words: qui, que, quoi, où, quand, comment, combien, pourquoi

French	Pronunciation	English	Example
qui	*kee*	who	Qui vient ce soir ?
que	*kuh*	what (formal, + inversion)	Que fais-tu ?
qu'est-ce que	*kes-kuh*	what (standard)	Qu'est-ce que tu fais ?
quoi	*kwah*	what (casual, at the end or after a preposition)	Tu fais quoi ?
où	*oo*	where	Où est-ce que tu habites ?
quand	*kahN*	when	Tu pars quand ?
comment	*koh-mahN*	how	Comment vas-tu ?
combien	*kohN-byaN*	how much, how many	C'est combien ?
combien de	*kohN-byaN duh*	how many (+ noun)	Combien de frères as-tu ?
pourquoi	*poor-kwah*	why	Pourquoi tu pars ?
parce que	*pars-kuh*	because	Parce qu'il pleut.

- **Où est-ce que tu habites ?** *(oo es-kuh tew ah-beet)* — *Where do you live?*
- **Quand est-ce que tu pars ?** *(kahN-tes-kuh tew par)* — *When are you leaving?*
- **Qu'est-ce que c'est ?** *(kes-kuh seh)* — *What is it?*
- **Pourquoi est-ce que tu apprends le français ?** *(poor-kwah es-kuh tew ah-prahN luh frahN-seh)* — *Why are you learning French?*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~Quoi tu fais ?~~ → ✓ **Qu'est-ce que tu fais ?** *(kes-kuh tew feh)* — quoi goes at the end or after a preposition.
- ✗ ~~Combien des frères as-tu ?~~ → ✓ **Combien de frères as-tu ?** *(kohN-byaN duh frair ah-tew)* — combien de + noun, no article.

See also: Asking questions, lesson 3 · Asking questions, lesson 4.

Quel, quelle, quels, quelles: which, what

When: "Which" or "what" with a noun, or with être + noun. It agrees with the noun.

quel, quelle, quels, quelles

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
quel	*kel*	which, what	m. sing.
quelle	*kel*	which, what	f. sing.
quels	*kel*	which, what	m. pl.; kel z before a vowel
quelles	*kel*	which, what	f. pl.; kel z before a vowel

- **Quelle heure est-il ?** *(kel uhr eh-teel)* — *What time is it?*
- **Quel âge as-tu ?** *(kel ahzh ah-tew)* — *How old are you?*
- **Quels amis viennent ?** *(kel zah-mee vyen)* — *Which friends are coming?*
- **Quel est ton nom ?** *(kel eh tohN nohN)* — *What is your name?*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~Quelle est ton nom ?~~ → ✓ **Quel est ton nom ?** *(kel eh tohN nohN)* — nom is masculine.
- ✗ ~~Quel est-ce que tu veux ?~~ → ✓ **Qu'est-ce que tu veux ?** *(kes-kuh tew vuh)* — quel needs a noun or être.

See also: Asking questions, lesson 5.

Lequel, laquelle: which one Preview

When: "Which one(s)?" when the noun is already clear. It agrees with that noun.

lequel, laquelle, lesquels, lesquelles

French	Pronunciation	English	Gender / number
lequel	*luh-kel*	which one	m. sing.
laquelle	*lah-kel*	which one	f. sing.
lesquels	*lay-kel*	which ones	m. pl.
lesquelles	*lay-kel*	which ones	f. pl.

- **Lequel préfères-tu ?** *(luh-kel pray-fair-tew)* — *Which one do you prefer? (a film)*
- **Laquelle veux-tu ?** *(lah-kel vuh-tew)* — *Which one do you want? (une tarte)*
- **Lesquels sont à toi ?** *(lay-kel sohN tah twah)* — *Which ones are yours? (des livres)*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~Quel préfères-tu ? (with no noun)~~ → ✓ **Lequel préfères-tu ?** *(luh-kel pray-fair-tew)* — no noun after it: use lequel.

See also: Asking questions, lesson 5.

6. Negation

Negative words

When: ne goes before the verb and the second word after it; ne becomes n' before a vowel. In casual speech the ne is often dropped.

Negative words: ne ... pas, jamais, plus, rien, personne, que, ni ... ni

French	Pronunciation	English	Example
ne ... pas	*nuh ... pah*	not	Je ne parle pas espagnol.
ne ... jamais	*nuh ... zhah-meh*	never	Il ne mange jamais de viande.
ne ... plus	*nuh ... plew*	no longer, not any more	Je n'habite plus ici.
ne ... rien	*nuh ... ryaN*	nothing, not anything	Je ne vois rien.
ne ... personne	*nuh ... pair-sun*	nobody, not anyone	Je ne connais personne.
ne ... que	*nuh ... kuh*	only	Je n'ai que dix euros.
ne ... ni ... ni	*nuh ... nee ... nee*	neither ... nor	Je ne bois ni thé ni café.

- **Je n'ai jamais vu Paris.** *(zhuh nay zhah-meh vew pah-ree)* — *I've never seen Paris.*
- **Il n'y a personne.** *(eel nee ah pair-sun)* — *There's nobody there.*
- **Rien ne va.** *(ryaN nuh vah)* — *Nothing is going right. (rien as the subject comes first)*
- **Je ne bois que de l'eau.** *(zhuh nuh bwah kuh duh loh)* — *I only drink water.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je ne vois pas rien.~~ → ✓ **Je ne vois rien.** *(zhuh nuh vwah ryaN)* — one negative word with ne, not pas + rien.
> - ne ... que is not really negative, so the article stays: Je n'ai que des pommes (zhuh nay kuh day pum).

See also: Pas de: after a negative.

Where the negative goes

When: In compound tenses and with pronouns, ne ... pas wraps around the first verb and the pronouns in front of it.

Word order with ne ... pas

French	Pronunciation	English	Rule
Je ne parle pas.	*zhuh nuh parl pah*	I don't speak.	ne + verb + pas
Je n'ai pas mangé.	*zhuh nay pah mahN-zhay*	I didn't eat.	ne + avoir/être + pas + participle
Je ne suis pas allé.	*zhuh nuh swee pah zah-lay*	I didn't go.	same with être
Je ne le vois pas.	*zhuh nuh luh vwah pah*	I don't see him.	ne + pronoun + verb + pas
Je ne me lève pas.	*zhuh nuh muh lev pah*	I don't get up.	ne + reflexive pronoun + verb + pas
Je ne veux pas partir.	*zhuh nuh vuh pah par-teer*	I don't want to leave.	ne ... pas around the first verb
Je n'ai vu personne.	*zhuh nay vew pair-sun*	I didn't see anyone.	personne goes after the participle

- **Elle n'est pas encore arrivée.** *(el neh pah zahN-kor ah-ree-vay)* — *She hasn't arrived yet.*
- **Je ne l'ai jamais vu.** *(zhuh nuh lay zhah-meh vew)* — *I've never seen it.*
- **Ne pas toucher.** *(nuh pah too-shay)* — *Do not touch. (before an infinitive both words go together)*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~Je n'ai mangé pas.~~ → ✓ **Je n'ai pas mangé.** *(zhuh nay pah mahN-zhay)* — pas goes right after avoir / être.
> - ✗ ~~Je ne vois le pas.~~ → ✓ **Je ne le vois pas.** *(zhuh nuh luh vwah pah)* — the pronoun stays glued to the verb.

See also: Reflexive verbs, lesson 3 (negatives).

7. Adjectives

Regular agreement patterns

When: Adjectives agree with the noun: add -e for feminine, -s for plural, -es for feminine plural. Some endings change.

Adjective agreement: masculine and feminine forms

French	Pronunciation	English	Pattern (m. → f.)
grand, grande	*grahN, grahNd*	tall, big	+ e
petit, petite	*puh-tee, puh-teet*	small	+ e (the t is now said)
jeune	*zhuhn*	young	ends in e: no change
grands, grandes	*grahN, grahNd*	tall, big	pl. + s / + es
heureux, heureuse	*uh-ruh, uh-ruhz*	happy	-eux → -euse
sportif, sportive	*spor-teef, spor-teev*	sporty	-if → -ive
cher, chère	*shair, shair*	expensive, dear	-er → -ère
premier, première	*pruh-myay, pruh-myair*	first	-ier → -ière
naturel, naturelle	*nah-tew-rel, nah-tew-rel*	natural	-el → -elle
bon, bonne	*bohN, bun*	good	-on → -onne
italien, italienne	*ee-tah-lyaN, ee-tah-lyen*	Italian	-ien → -ienne

- **Ma sœur est grande.** *(mah suhr eh grahNd)* — *My sister is tall.*
- **Elles sont heureuses.** *(el sohN tuh-ruhz)* — *They are happy.*
- **C'est une bonne idée.** *(seh tewn bun ee-day)* — *It's a good idea.*
- **Les chaussures sont chères.** *(lay shoh-sewr sohN shair)* — *The shoes are expensive.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~une maison petit~~ → ✓ **une petite maison** *(ewn puh-teet meh-zohN)* — agree, and petit goes before the noun (BAGS).
> - Adding -e often makes a silent final consonant heard: petit (puh-tee) → petite (puh-teet).

Common irregular adjectives

When: These change more. beau, nouveau and vieux have a special masculine form before a vowel or mute h. Plurals:

beaux, belles · nouveaux, nouvelles · vieux, vieilles.

Irregular adjectives: beau, nouveau, vieux, blanc, long, gentil

French	Pronunciation	English	Forms
beau	*boh*	beautiful, handsome	m.
bel	*bel*	beautiful, handsome	m. before a vowel: un bel homme
belle	*bel*	beautiful	f.
nouveau	*noo-voh*	new	m.
nouvel	*noo-vel*	new	m. before a vowel: un nouvel ami
nouvelle	*noo-vel*	new	f.
vieux	*vyuh*	old	m. (pl. vieux)
vieil	*vyehy*	old	m. before a vowel: un vieil homme
vieille	*vyehy*	old	f.
blanc	*blahN*	white	m.
blanche	*blahNsh*	white	f.
long	*lohN*	long	m.
longue	*lohNg*	long	f.
gentil	*zhahN-tee*	kind, nice	m.
gentille	*zhahN-teey*	kind, nice	f.

- **C'est un bel appartement.** *(seh tuhN bel ah-par-tuh-mahN) — It's a beautiful flat.*
- **J'ai un nouvel ordinateur.** *(zhay uhN noo-vel or-dee-nah-tuhr) — I have a new computer.*
- **Ma grand-mère est une vieille dame.** *(mah grahN-mair eh tewn vyehy dahm) — My grandmother is an old lady.*
- **Elle porte une robe blanche.** *(el port ewn rob blahNsh) — She's wearing a white dress.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~un beau homme~~ → ✓ **un bel homme** *(uhN bel um)* — bel, nouvel, vieil before a vowel or mute h (singular only).
> - ✗ ~~une robe blance~~ → ✓ **une robe blanche** *(ewn rob blahNsh)*

Adjectives that go before the noun: BAGS

When: Most adjectives go after the noun (une voiture rouge). A short list of common ones goes before: Beauty, Age, Goodness, Size.

BAGS adjectives and adjective position

French	Pronunciation	English	BAGS
beau, joli	*boh, zhoh-lee*	beautiful, pretty	Beauty
jeune, vieux, nouveau	*zhuhn, vyuh, noo-voh*	young, old, new	Age
bon, mauvais	*bohN, moh-veh*	good, bad	Goodness
grand, petit, gros	*grahN, puh-tee, groh*	big or tall, small, fat or big	Size
une jolie maison	*ewn zhoh-lee meh-zohN*	a pretty house	before
une voiture rouge	*ewn vwah-tewr roozh*	a red car	after (colour)
un film intéressant	*uhN feelm aN-tay-reh-sahN*	an interesting film	after (most adjectives)

- **C'est un petit village.** *(seh tuhN puh-tee vee-lahzh) — It's a small village.*
- **J'ai un bon ami.** *(zhay uhN bohN nah-mee) — I have a good friend.*
- **Il a une voiture noire.** *(eel ah ewn vwah-tewr nwahr) — He has a black car.*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~une rouge voiture~~ → ✓ **une voiture rouge** *(ewn vwah-tewr roozh)* — colours and nationalities go after.
- Before an adjective in the plural, des usually becomes de: de bons amis (duh bohN zah-mee). This is a B1 detail; casual speech often keeps des.

8. Prepositions

Prepositions of place

When: To say where something is. Remember à + le = au and de + le = du: à côté du lit, près de la gare.

Prepositions of place

French	Pronunciation	English	With le, la, les
sur	*sewr*	on	
sous	*soo*	under	
devant	*duh-vahN*	in front of	
derrière	*dair-yair*	behind	
dans	*dahN*	in, inside	
entre	*ahN-truh*	between	
à côté de	*ah koh-tay duh*	next to	du / de la / des
près de	*preh duh*	near	du / de la / des
loin de	*lwaN duh*	far from	du / de la / des
en face de	*ahN fahs duh*	opposite	du / de la / des

- **Le chat est sous la table.** *(luh shah eh soo lah tah-bluh)* — *The cat is under the table.*
- **La banque est à côté de la poste.** *(lah bahNk eh tah koh-tay duh lah post)* — *The bank is next to the post office.*
- **J'habite près du parc.** *(zhah-beet preh dew park)* — *I live near the park.*
- **Le café est en face de l'hôtel.** *(luh kah-fay eh tahN fahs duh loh-tel)* — *The café is opposite the hotel.*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~près de le parc~~ → ✓ **près du parc** *(preh dew park)* — de + le = du.
- ✗ ~~à côté la gare~~ → ✓ **à côté de la gare** *(ah koh-tay duh lah gar)* — keep the de.

See also: à and de + the article.

Cities and countries: à, en, au, aux

When: "In" or "to" a place. Most countries ending in -e are feminine (la France); a few are not (le Mexique, le Cambodge).

à, en, au, aux with cities and countries

French	Pronunciation	English	Use with
à Paris	*ah pah-ree*	in / to Paris	à + city
en France	*ahN frahNs*	in / to France	en + f. country
en Italie	*ahN nee-tah-lee*	in / to Italy	en + country starting with a vowel
au Canada	*oh kah-nah-dah*	in / to Canada	au + m. country
au Japon	*oh zhah-pohN*	in / to Japan	au + m. country
aux États-Unis	*oh zay-tah-zew-nee*	in / to the United States	aux + pl. country
de France	*duh frahNs*	from France	de + f. country
du Canada	*dew kah-nah-dah*	from Canada	du + m. country

- **J'habite à Londres.** *(zhah-beet ah lohN-druh)* — *I live in London.*
- **Nous allons en Espagne.** *(noo zah-lohN ahN nes-pahny)* — *We're going to Spain.*
- **Il travaille au Portugal.** *(eel trah-vahy oh por-tew-gahl)* — *He works in Portugal.*
- **Elle revient des États-Unis.** *(el ruh-vyaN day zay-tah-zew-nee)* — *She's coming back from the United States.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~à France~~ → ✓ **en France** *(ahN frahNs)* — à is for cities; countries take en / au / aux.
> - ✗ ~~en Canada~~ → ✓ **au Canada** *(oh kah-nah-dah)* — masculine countries take au.

9. Verb reference

A summary only. The full verb tables, with every form and a Listen button, are in Learn.

See also: Learn: all verbs · Lesson 2: regular -er verbs · parler · finir · attendre · aller · venir · se lever · Reflexive verbs, lesson 4 (past and future).

Present-tense endings

When: Regular verbs: drop -er, -ir or -re and add the endings. -er: -e, -es, -e, -ons, -ez, -ent · -ir: -is, -is, -it, -issons, -issez, -issent · -re: -s, -s, (nothing), -ons, -ez, -ent.

Present tense of parler, finir and attendre

Person	-er: parler	-ir: finir	-re: attendre
je	je parle *zhuh parl*	je finis *zhuh fee-nee*	j'attends *zhah-tahN*
tu	tu parles *tew parl*	tu finis *tew fee-nee*	tu attends *tew ah-tahN*
il/elle	il parle *eel parl*	il finit *eel fee-nee*	il attend *eel ah-tahN*
nous	nous parlons *noo par-lohN*	nous finissons *noo fee-nee-sohN*	nous attendons *noo zah-tahN-dohN*
vous	vous parlez *voo par-lay*	vous finissez *voo fee-nee-say*	vous attendez *voo zah-tahN-day*
ils/elles	ils parlent *eel parl*	ils finissent *eel fee-nees*	ils attendent *eel zah-tahNd*

- **Nous finissons à cinq heures.** *(noo fee-nee-sohN ah saN kuhr)* — *We finish at five.*
- **Il attend le bus.** *(eel ah-tahN luh bews)* — *He's waiting for the bus.*

> **Watch out**
> - The je, tu, il and ils forms of -er verbs all sound the same: parle, parles, parle, parlent = parl.
> - -ir verbs like partir, sortir and dormir do NOT follow finir: je pars, nous partons.

See also: parler · finir · attendre · partir.

Verbs that take être in the passé composé

When: These verbs (mostly movement or change of state) and ALL pronominal verbs form the passé composé with

être, and the participle agrees with the subject. Memory aid: DR & MRS VANDERTRAMPP.

Verbs with être in the passé composé (DR & MRS VANDERTRAMPP)

French	Pronunciation	English	Past (je)
devenir	*duh-vuh-neer*	to become	je suis devenu(e)
revenir	*ruh-vuh-neer*	to come back	je suis revenu(e)
monter	*mohN-tay*	to go up	je suis monté(e)
rester	*res-tay*	to stay	je suis resté(e)
sortir	*sor-teer*	to go out	je suis sorti(e)
venir	*vuh-neer*	to come	je suis venu(e)
aller	*ah-lay*	to go	je suis allé(e)
naître	*neh-truh*	to be born	je suis né(e)
descendre	*deh-sahN-druh*	to go down	je suis descendu(e)
entrer	*ahN-tray*	to enter	je suis entré(e)
rentrer	*rahN-tray*	to go home	je suis rentré(e)
tomber	*tohN-bay*	to fall	je suis tombé(e)
retourner	*ruh-toor-nay*	to return	je suis retourné(e)
arriver	*ah-ree-vay*	to arrive	je suis arrivé(e)
mourir	*moo-reer*	to die	je suis mort(e)
partir	*par-teer*	to leave	je suis parti(e)
passer	*pah-say*	to pass by	je suis passé(e)
se lever (and all reflexive verbs)	*suh luh-vay*	to get up	je me suis levé(e)

- **Elle est arrivée hier.** *(el eh tah-ree-vay yair)* — *She arrived yesterday.*
- **Nous sommes allés au cinéma.** *(noo sum zah-lay oh see-nay-mah)* — *We went to the cinema.*
- **Je me suis levé à sept heures.** *(zhuh muh swee luh-vay ah set uhr)* — *I got up at seven.*

> **Watch out**
> - ✗ ~~J'ai allé~~ → ✓ **Je suis allé(e)** *(zhuh swee zah-lay)*
> - With a direct object, monter, descendre, sortir, rentrer and passer take avoir: J'ai monté les valises (zhay mohN-tay lay vah-leez).

See also: Reflexive verbs, lesson 4 (past).

Futur simple: endings and irregular stems

When: "Will". Regular verbs: the infinitive (drop the final e of -re) + -ai, -as, -a, -ons, -ez, -ont. Irregular verbs use a

special stem with the same endings.

Future endings (parler) and irregular future stems

French	Pronunciation	English	Ending / stem
je parlerai	*zhuh par-luh-ray*	I will speak	-ai
tu parleras	*tew par-luh-rah*	you will speak	-as
il parlera	*eel par-luh-rah*	he will speak	-a
nous parlerons	*noo par-luh-rohN*	we will speak	-ons
vous parlerez	*voo par-luh-ray*	you will speak	-ez
ils parleront	*eel par-luh-rohN*	they will speak	-ont
je serai	*zhuh suh-ray*	I will be	être: ser-
j'aurai	*zhoh-ray*	I will have	avoir: aur-
j'irai	*zhee-ray*	I will go	aller: ir-
je ferai	*zhuh fuh-ray*	I will do	faire: fer-
je pourrai	*zhuh poo-ray*	I will be able to	pouvoir: pourr-
je voudrai	*zhuh voo-dray*	I will want	vouloir: voudr-
je devrai	*zhuh duh-vray*	I will have to	devoir: devr-
je saurai	*zhuh soh-ray*	I will know	savoir: saur-
je verrai	*zhuh veh-ray*	I will see	voir: verr-
je viendrai	*zhuh vyaN-dray*	I will come	venir: viendr-
je tiendrai	*zhuh tyaN-dray*	I will hold	tenir: tiendr-
je recevrai	*zhuh ruh-suh-vray*	I will receive	recevoir: recevr-
j'enverrai	*zhahN-veh-ray*	I will send	envoyer: enverr-
je courrai	*zhuh koor-ray*	I will run	courir: courr-
je mourrai	*zhuh moor-ray*	I will die	mourir: mourr-
il faudra	*eel foh-drah*	it will be necessary	falloir: faudr-
il pleuvra	*eel pluh-vrah*	it will rain	pleuvoir: pleuvr-

- **Demain, il fera beau.** *(duh-maN, eel fuh-rah boh) — Tomorrow the weather will be nice.*
- **Nous irons en France.** *(noo zee-rohN ahN frahNs) — We will go to France.*

> **Watch out**
> - The endings are the present of avoir (ai, as, a, ons, ez, ont); the stem always ends in r.
> - ✗ ~~je allerai~~ → ✓ **j'irai** *(zhee-ray)*
> - The near future is more common in speech: aller + infinitive, Je vais partir (zhuh veh par-teer).

See also: Reflexive verbs, lesson 4 (future).

Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen

When: Stem = the nous form of the present minus -ons (nous parlons → parl-), + -ais, -ais, -ait, -ions, -iez, -aient. Only être is irregular (ét-). Use it for descriptions, the background and habits ("was …-ing", "used to"); use the passé

composé for single completed events.

Imparfait endings (parler) and stems from the nous form

French	Pronunciation	English	Ending / stem
je parlais	*zhuh par-leh*	I was speaking / I used to speak	-ais
tu parlais	*tew par-leh*	you were speaking	-ais
il parlait	*eel par-leh*	he was speaking	-ait
nous parlions	*noo par-lyohN*	we were speaking	-ions
vous parliez	*voo par-lyay*	you were speaking	-iez
ils parlaient	*eel par-leh*	they were speaking	-aient
je finissais	*zhuh fee-nee-seh*	I was finishing	nous finissons → finiss-
j'avais	*zhah-veh*	I had / I used to have	nous avons → av-
je faisais	*zhuh fuh-zeh*	I was doing	nous faisons → fais-
j'allais	*zhah-leh*	I was going	nous allons → all-
je prenais	*zhuh pruh-neh*	I was taking	nous prenons → pren-
j'étais	*zhay-teh*	I was	être: ét-
il pleuvait	*eel pluh-veh*	it was raining	pleuvoir: pleuv-

- **Il pleuvait.** *(eel pluh-veh)* — *It was raining.*
- **Quand j'étais petite, j'habitais à Lyon.** *(kahN zhay-teh puh-teet, zhah-bee-teh ah lee-ohN)* — *When I was little, I lived in Lyon.*
- **Je lisais quand le téléphone a sonné.** *(zhuh lee-zeh kahN luh tay-lay-fun ah su-nay)* — *I was reading when the phone rang.*

> **Watch out**
> - je parlais, tu parlais, il parlait and ils parlaient all sound the same: par-leh.
> - Imparfait for the background or a habit; passé composé for the event that happens in it: Il pleuvait quand elle est arrivée.
> - ✗ ~~j'étions~~ → ✓ **nous étions** *(noo zay-tyohN)*

See also: être · avoir · faire · Verbs with être in the passé composé.

Conditional: would, could, polite requests

When: "Would". The future stem (the infinitive, or the irregular future stem) + the imparfait endings -ais, -ais, -ait, -ions, -iez, -aient. Use it for polite requests (je voudrais, pourriez-vous), advice (tu devrais) and hypotheses (si + imparfait →

conditional).

Conditional endings (parler) and irregular stems

French	Pronunciation	English	Ending / stem
je parlerais	*zhuh par-luh-reh*	I would speak	-ais
tu parlerais	*tew par-luh-reh*	you would speak	-ais
il parlerait	*eel par-luh-reh*	he would speak	-ait
nous parlerions	*noo par-luh-ryohN*	we would speak	-ions
vous parleriez	*voo par-luh-ryay*	you would speak	-iez
ils parleraient	*eel par-luh-reh*	they would speak	-aient
je serais	*zhuh suh-reh*	I would be	être: ser-
j'aurais	*zhoh-reh*	I would have	avoir: aur-
j'irais	*zhee-reh*	I would go	aller: ir-
je ferais	*zhuh fuh-reh*	I would do	faire: fer-
je pourrais	*zhuh poo-reh*	I could	pouvoir: pourr-
je voudrais	*zhuh voo-dreh*	I would like	vouloir: voudr-
je devrais	*zhuh duh-vreh*	I should	devoir: devr-
je viendrais	*zhuh vyaN-dreh*	I would come	venir: viendr-
je verrais	*zhuh veh-reh*	I would see	voir: verr-
je saurais	*zhuh soh-reh*	I would know	savoir: saur-
j'aimerais	*zhem-reh*	I would like / I would love	aimer: aimer-
ce serait	*suh suh-reh*	it would be	être: ser-

- **Je voudrais un café, s'il vous plaît.** *(zhuh voo-dreh uhN kah-fay, seel voo pleh) — I'd like a coffee, please.*
- **Pourriez-vous m'aider ?** *(poo-ryay voo meh-day) — Could you help me?*
- **Si j'avais le temps, je viendrais.** *(see zhah-veh luh tahN, zhuh vyaN-dreh) — If I had the time, I would come.*
- **Tu devrais lui écrire.** *(tew duh-vreh lwee ay-kreer) — You should write to him.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Si j'aurais le temps…~~ → ✓ **Si j'avais le temps, je viendrais.** *(see zhah-veh luh tahN, zhuh vyaN-dreh)* — never the conditional right after si: si + imparfait, then the conditional.
> - Future or conditional? je voudrai (zhuh voo-dray) = I will want; je voudrais (zhuh voo-dreh) = I would like. Only the ending sound changes.
> - Preview (B1): the past conditional is avoir or être in the conditional + the past participle. Si j'étais arrivée plus tôt, il aurait lu la lettre (see zhay-teh ah-ree-vay plew toh, eel oh-reh lew lah let-ruh) = If I had got there earlier, he would have read the letter.

See also: vouloir · pouvoir · devoir · Futur simple: endings and irregular stems · Imparfait.

10. Everyday basics

Numbers 0–20

When: Counting, prices, ages and phone numbers. Learn 0–16 by heart; 17, 18 and 19 are 10 + 7, 8, 9.

Numbers from 0 to 20

French	Pronunciation	English
zéro	*zay-roh*	0
un	*uhN*	1 (une with a f. noun: ewn)
deux	*duh*	2
trois	*trwah*	3
quatre	*kah-truh*	4
cinq	*saNk*	5
six	*sees*	6
sept	*set*	7
huit	*weet*	8
neuf	*nuhf*	9
dix	*dees*	10
onze	*ohNz*	11
douze	*dooz*	12
treize	*trez*	13
quatorze	*kah-torz*	14
quinze	*kaNz*	15
seize	*sez*	16
dix-sept	*dee-set*	17
dix-huit	*deez-weet*	18
dix-neuf	*deez-nuhf*	19
vingt	*vaN*	20

- **J'ai trois enfants.** *(zhay trwah zahN-fahN) — I have three children.*
- **Il a dix-huit ans.** *(eel ah deez-wee tahN) — He is eighteen.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - Before a consonant, cinq, six, huit and dix often lose their final sound: six livres (see leevr). Before a vowel they link: six ans (see zahN).
> - ✗ ~~Il est dix-huit.~~ → ✓ **Il a dix-huit ans.** *(eel ah deez-wee tahN)* — age uses avoir and always ans.

Numbers 21–100

When: From 70, French counts in twenties: 70 = 60 + 10, 80 = 4 × 20, 90 = 4 × 20 + 10. Use et un for 21, 31, 41, 51

and 61, and et onze for 71; there is no et in 81 or 91.

Numbers from 21 to 100

French	Pronunciation	English	Built as
vingt et un	*vaN-tay-uhN*	21	20 et 1
vingt-deux	*vaNt-duh*	22	20-2
trente	*trahNt*	30	
trente et un	*trahN-tay-uhN*	31	30 et 1
quarante	*kah-rahNt*	40	
cinquante	*saN-kahNt*	50	
soixante	*swah-sahNt*	60	
soixante-dix	*swah-sahNt-dees*	70	60 + 10
soixante et onze	*swah-sahN-tay-ohNz*	71	60 et 11
soixante-douze	*swah-sahNt-dooz*	72	60 + 12
quatre-vingts	*kah-truh-vaN*	80	4 × 20 (with s)
quatre-vingt-un	*kah-truh-vaN-uhN*	81	4 × 20 + 1 (no s, no et)
quatre-vingt-dix	*kah-truh-vaN-dees*	90	4 × 20 + 10
quatre-vingt-onze	*kah-truh-vaN-ohNz*	91	4 × 20 + 11
quatre-vingt-dix-neuf	*kah-truh-vaN-deez-nuhf*	99	4 × 20 + 19
cent	*sahN*	100	

- **Ma grand-mère a quatre-vingts ans.** *(mah grahN-mair ah kah-truh-vaN zahN) — My grandmother is eighty.*
- **Ça coûte soixante-quinze euros.** *(sah koot swah-sahNt-kaNz uh-roh) — It costs seventy-five euros.*
- **Il y a trente et un jours en mai.** *(eel ee ah trahN-tay-uhN zhoor ahN meh) — There are thirty-one days in May.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~quatre-vingts-un~~ → ✓ **quatre-vingt-un** *(kah-truh-vaN-uhN)* — quatre-vingts keeps its s only when nothing follows.
> - ✗ ~~quatre-vingt et un~~ → ✓ **quatre-vingt-un** *(kah-truh-vaN-uhN)* — no et in 81 or 91.
> - In Belgium and Switzerland you'll also hear septante (70) and nonante (90); in Switzerland huitante (80).

Ordinal numbers: first, second...

When: Add -ième to the number (drop a final e). Dates use le premier, then plain numbers: le deux mai.

Ordinal numbers

French	Pronunciation	English	Note
premier	*pruh-myay*	first	m.; 1er
première	*pruh-myair*	first	f.; 1re
deuxième	*duh-zyem*	second	2e
troisième	*trwah-zyem*	third	3e
quatrième	*kah-tree-yem*	fourth	drop the e
cinquième	*saN-kyem*	fifth	add u
neuvième	*nuh-vyem*	ninth	f → v
dixième	*dee-zyem*	tenth	
vingtième	*vaN-tyem*	twentieth	

- **J'habite au troisième étage.** *(zhah-beet oh trwah-zyem ay-tahzh) — I live on the third floor.*
- **C'est le premier mai.** *(seh luh pruh-myay meh) — It's the first of May.*
- **C'est le deux mai.** *(seh luh duh meh) — It's the second of May.*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~le deuxième mai~~ → ✓ **le deux mai** *(luh duh meh)* — only the 1st takes premier in dates.

Days of the week

When: No capital letters in French. Use le for a regular day: le lundi = on Mondays. For one day, no word for "on": lundi = on Monday.

Days of the week

French	Pronunciation	English
lundi	*luhN-dee*	Monday
mardi	*mar-dee*	Tuesday
mercredi	*mair-kruh-dee*	Wednesday
jeudi	*zhuh-dee*	Thursday
vendredi	*vahN-druh-dee*	Friday
samedi	*sahm-dee*	Saturday
dimanche	*dee-mahNsh*	Sunday

- **Je travaille le lundi.** *(zhuh trah-vahy luh luhN-dee)* — *I work on Mondays.*
- **On se voit samedi ?** *(ohN suh vwah sahm-dee)* — *Shall we meet on Saturday?*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~Lundi~~ → ✓ **lundi** *(luhN-dee)* — no capital letter.
- ✗ ~~sur lundi~~ → ✓ **lundi** *(luhN-dee)* — no word for "on" with a single day.

Months

When: No capital letters. In a month: en mai or au mois de mai.

Months of the year

French	Pronunciation	English
janvier	*zhahN-vyay*	January
février	*fay-vree-yay*	February
mars	*mars*	March
avril	*ah-vreel*	April
mai	*meh*	May
juin	*zhwaN*	June
juillet	*zhwee-yeh*	July
août	*oot*	August
septembre	*sep-tahN-bruh*	September
octobre	*ok-toh-bruh*	October
novembre	*noh-vahN-bruh*	November
décembre	*day-sahN-bruh*	December

- **Mon anniversaire est en juillet.** *(mohN nah-nee-vair-sair eh tahN zhwee-yeh)* — *My birthday is in July.*
- **Je pars en août.** *(zhuh par ahN noot)* — *I'm leaving in August.*
- **Il fait froid en décembre.** *(eel feh frwah ahN day-sahN-bruh)* — *It's cold in December.*

Watch out

- ✗ ~~Juillet~~ → ✓ **juillet** *(zhwee-yeh)* — no capital letter.
- ✗ ~~dans mai~~ → ✓ **en mai** *(ahN meh)* — use en (or au mois de) with a month.

Telling the time

When: Il est + number + heure(s). Schedules, trains and shops use the 24-hour clock.

Telling the time

French	Pronunciation	English	Time
Quelle heure est-il ?	*kel uhr eh-teel*	What time is it?	
Il est une heure.	*eel eh tewn uhr*	It's one o'clock.	1:00
Il est deux heures.	*eel eh duh zuhr*	It's two o'clock.	2:00
Il est trois heures cinq.	*eel eh trwah zuhr saNk*	It's five past three.	3:05
Il est quatre heures et quart.	*eel eh kah-truhr ay kar*	It's quarter past four.	4:15
Il est cinq heures et demie.	*eel eh saN kuhr ay duh-mee*	It's half past five.	5:30
Il est six heures moins le quart.	*eel eh see zuhr mwaN luh kar*	It's quarter to six.	5:45
Il est sept heures moins dix.	*eel eh set uhr mwaN dees*	It's ten to seven.	6:50
Il est midi.	*eel eh mee-dee*	It's noon.	12:00
Il est minuit.	*eel eh mee-nwee*	It's midnight.	0:00
Il est dix-huit heures trente.	*eel eh deez-wee tuhr trahNt*	It's 6:30 pm.	18:30 (24-hour)
à huit heures	*ah wee tuhr*	at eight o'clock	at

- **Le film commence à vingt heures.** *(luh feelm koh-mahNs ah vaN tuhr)* — *The film starts at 8 pm.*
- **On se retrouve à midi et demi ?** *(ohN suh ruh-troov ah mee-dee ay duh-mee)* — *Shall we meet at half past twelve?*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~Il est deux.~~ → ✓ **Il est deux heures.** *(eel eh duh zuhr)* — always say heure(s).
> - et demie after heure(s) (f.), but midi et demi and minuit et demi (no e).

See also: Asking questions, lesson 5 (Quelle heure est-il ?).

Common time expressions

When: Words for when and how often. They usually go at the start or the end of the sentence.

Common time expressions

French	Pronunciation	English
aujourd'hui	*oh-zhoor-dwee*	today
demain	*duh-maN*	tomorrow
hier	*yair*	yesterday
maintenant	*maNt-nahN*	now
ce matin	*suh mah-taN*	this morning
ce soir	*suh swahr*	this evening, tonight
cette semaine	*set suh-men*	this week
le week-end	*luh wee-kend*	at the weekend
la semaine prochaine	*lah suh-men proh-shen*	next week
l'année dernière	*lah-nay dair-nyair*	last year
tous les jours	*too lay zhoor*	every day
souvent	*soo-vahN*	often
toujours	*too-zhoor*	always, still
parfois	*par-fwah*	sometimes
il y a deux jours	*eel ee ah duh zhoor*	two days ago
depuis	*duh-pwee*	since, for

- **J'apprends le français depuis un an.** *(zhah-prahN luh frahN-seh duh-pwee uhN nahN)* — *I've been learning French for a year.*
- **Je suis arrivé il y a deux jours.** *(zhuh swee zah-ree-vay eel ee ah duh zhoor)* — *I arrived two days ago.*

> **Watch out**
>
> - ✗ ~~J'apprends le français pour un an.~~ → ✓ **J'apprends le français depuis un an.** *(zhah-prahN luh frahN-seh duh-pwee uhN nahN)* — depuis + present for something still going on.